apt to believe that the Persian political system was much as it was prior to the war – based on personalities – and that the way to achieve anything was to work with sympathetic individuals.[27] Much of Norman's communication with London was spent trying to explain that the old system was in decline. As he told the Foreign Office in April 1921, the forces of nationalism within Persia were now so strong that any prime minister that hoped to survive had to harness this force and, hence, had to be seen to be internationalising and reforming the country.[28]

Just how precarious a position any Persian government was in is apparent simply from looking at how short their terms of office were. Seyyed Zia'eddin had come to power following a coup d'état by the commander of the Cossack Division, Reza Khan (Staroselskii's successor), who had claimed that he was 'tired of seeing one inefficient Government succeed another at Tehran'.[29] Yet, within a few months, Zia'eddin had been ousted – ostensibly because of his 'pro-British attitude' – and replaced with Qavam os-Saltaneh.[30] Such political turbulence did not make for better relations between Britain and Persia. Probably aware of his precarious position, the new Persian prime minister, os-Saltaneh, immediately sent to London a communication of friendship. He hoped, of course, that the British government realised that he had to remain 'impartial', in Persia's foreign relations, but that this would not prevent Britain from giving its support to himself and his new Cabinet. Nevertheless, Lancelot Oliphant epitomised the British Foreign Office's view when he noted that it appeared that 'the new [Persian] Cabinet wished to keep their cake and yet eat it': it wanted to place all nations with an interest in its country on a par, and yet gain all the advantages which Britain had bestowed on previous Persian governments 'which had actively worked with us'.[31] Curzon, meanwhile, was apparently entirely sick of a succession of Persian ministers 'all taking anti-British action but sneaking round to protest British sympathies'. As for the constant interchange of personnel in the Persian government, this elicited in the British foreign secretary 'no more concern than the rapid and inevitable fall of (British) wickets in an International test match'.[32]

What made the Persian government's position even harder in 1921 was the decision by the British Cabinet to recall its troops from north Persia by the spring of that year. This resolution sent panic through the officials in